



Facebook Lite

A version of Facebook that makes it easier for those with bandwidth problems. Lite allows just the basics like Photos and Events

Tagging friends

You can now "tag" friends or companies that you have mentioned in status updates simply by adding the '@' symbol before the name

Featuring Facebook



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A significant shift has occurred in social networking trends among the Indian youth over the last one year: almost everybody who ever had an Orkut account now has one on Facebook – and few have even opted out of Orkut altogether. Over the last four months, the number of active users of Facebook has more than doubled and July 2009 saw more than 3.2 million Indian users. Comscore, the internet marketing and research company, says 68.2

per cent of the time spent by Indians on social networking, was spent on Orkut. But just ask your friends and family about which hangout they prefer while on the net and you'll probably find the Comscore results surprising. Let's face it: for a growing number of Indians, Facebook is the new Orkut.

One reason for Facebook's growing popularity is its aggressive marketing strategy. Facebook has ensured it stays visible in the media through tie-ups with various major companies such as Aircel for mobile internet services, Vodafone (and their ZooZoos)

Social networking web sites such as Facebook aren't always about wasting your time. There's a lot you can do with it. There are apps from games to professional utilities – all at one place...

for free access to Facebook – with all its pokes, updates and egg sending – on your cell phone, and Viacom's MTV (India) for 'Celebrity Connect' – finding out which celebs you resemble. Its failed attempt to buy Twitter, and the recent acquisition of FriendFeed – has also helped to keep it in the public eye.

The other reason is that it's packed with dozens of unique features, an immensely interactive, instantly gratifying and deeply interesting range of applications (or 'apps'), and surprising tweaks that let you have fun while being in constant touch with your friends and family. Let's take a peek at a few of the things that you could do on (and with) Facebook to bring the 'social' back into your network and to make it more exciting, entertaining and cool.

Applications

Log in to Facebook.com and take a good look at the bottom left corner of the screen. You can't miss that little button on the toolbar, which says 'f applications'. On the 'f applications' toolbar, click on the link that says 'Browse More Applications'. This will open up a Pandora's box of applications for you to choose from.

Games

We'll start this quick tour of applications with a look at

three of the most happening games on the Facebook site, in order of popularity.

Farmville: While about 62 per cent of the Indian population is actually employed in the agricultural sector, all of a sudden, the population of virtual farmers has boomed, thanks to Farmville. This online game in which anyone can set up and cultivate his/her own virtual farm has nearly 35 million users and is definitely the most popular game on Facebook.

Developed by Zynga, San Francisco, it allows you to become an online farmer – plant, grow, harvest and sell crops, buy or breed livestock – to earn 'coin income'. Each crop requires a few hours to grow (Tomatoes need eight hours, Raspberries need two, sunflowers need 23 and so on) and each give you an XP (short for experience).

The more crops and trees you plant, the more experience you earn. Farmers can invite other Facebook friends to become neighbours and send special gifts according to the level. Access to which crops you can grow depends on the number of points you've got – and therefore, which level you've reached in the game – pineapple seeds, for example, are only available to you once you reach level 15 (Professor of Agriculture) having gathered 4,500 points.